

◀ BEFORE

Diem's pro-Catholic policies only continued the discrimination that South Vietnam's 10.5 million Buddhists had endured under French colonial rule.

HISTORY OF RESILIENCE

Buddhism had been practiced in Vietnam since at least the second century, occasionally falling out of favor with royal rulers and their courts. During their **rule of Indochina**, the French encouraged the spread of Christianity. Seeing Buddhism as a threat, they passed laws to prevent its spread and growth. Diem, a Catholic, **refused to repeal** these French laws.



FIFTEENTH-CENTURY BUDDHA STATUE

Diem clearly favored fellow Catholics: he appointed them to key civil service and military jobs and gave them free choice of the land distributed by the government. This favoritism, however, caused deepening resentment among the nation's Buddhists, who made up more than 70 percent of the population. Buddhist hostility to the regime remained latent until an incident in Hue propelled them into open opposition to the Diem regime.

Buddhist protest

Hue was the spiritual center of South Vietnamese Buddhism. On May 8, 1963, thousands assembled there to celebrate the Buddha's 2,587th birthday. The local administration, however, forbade the flying of the Buddhist flag to commemorate the occasion. Many Buddhists gathered outside the radio station in protest, to listen to a speech by Buddhist leader Thich (venerable) Tri Quang.

Claiming that the speech had not been authorized by the censors, the station director refused to allow Quang to broadcast. He also summoned Major Dang Xi, a Catholic and the deputy province chief, to the scene. Xi ordered the crowd to disperse and, when the Buddhists failed to do so, told his men to open fire. As the crowd stampeded, 14 people, two of whom were children, were shot or trampled to death. The Buddhists were outraged.